

Don't Take the Bait.

Understanding Phishing Attacks



WHAT IS PHISHING?

Phishing is a type of cyberattack where criminals send fake emails, messages, or links to trick people into giving away personal information like passwords, credit card numbers, or banking details.



Deception

Attackers pretend to be someone you trust — your bank, your boss, or even a friend.



Fake Links

They send links to fake websites that look real to steal your login details.



Urgency

They create panic — 'Act now or your account will be closed!' — to make you act without thinking.

WHY SHOULD YOU CARE?

3.4B

Phishing emails
sent every day

83%

Of organisations
faced phishing
in 2023

#1

Most common
cyberattack
method

\$17,700

Lost per minute
due to phishing
attacks

Phishing is not just an IT problem — it can happen to **ANYONE**, including you.

TYPES OF PHISHING



Email Phishing

The most common type. Fake emails pretending to be from banks, companies, or colleagues to steal your information.



Spear Phishing

Targeted attacks on a specific person using personal details to make the email look convincing and legitimate.



Smishing

Phishing through SMS text messages. Fake texts claiming to be from delivery services, banks, or government agencies.



Vishing

Voice phishing — scam phone calls pretending to be from tech support, banks, or even your university IT team.



Whaling

Attacks targeting senior executives or high-value targets like CEOs and directors with large financial authority.



Pharming

Redirecting users to a fake website even when they type the correct URL into their browser.

HOW A PHISHING ATTACK WORKS

STEP 1



Attacker sends fake email

Disguised as your bank, boss, or a trusted service

STEP 2



You open the email

It looks real — correct logo, professional layout

STEP 3



You click the link

The link goes to a fake website that looks genuine

STEP 4



You enter your details

Login, password, credit card — all captured

STEP 5



Attacker has your data

Identity theft, financial loss, account takeover

HOW TO SPOT A PHISHING EMAIL

Urgent language



Phrases like "Act NOW!" or "Your account will be deleted!" are designed to panic you.

Suspicious sender



The email looks right but check carefully — "support@paypa1.com" is NOT PayPal.

Strange links



Hover over any link before clicking. The real URL shown may be completely different.

Poor spelling



Many phishing emails contain grammar mistakes or awkward phrasing that official emails would not have.

Unexpected attachments



Did not ask for a file? Do not open it. Attachments can contain hidden malware.

Generic greeting



"Dear Customer" instead of your name is a red flag. Legitimate companies use your real name.

REAL LIFE EXAMPLES

2013 Target (USA)

40M+ credit cards stolen

Hackers sent a phishing email to a third-party vendor working with Target. Using the stolen credentials, they accessed Target's network and stole payment card data from over 40 million customers.

2016 FACC (Austria)

\$54 Million lost

An employee received a fake email appearing to come from the CEO, requesting an urgent fund transfer for a secret acquisition project. The employee transferred \$54 million before the fraud was discovered.

2020 Twitter Hack

130 accounts hijacked

Attackers called Twitter employees pretending to be from the IT department and tricked them into giving up their credentials. They then hijacked major accounts including Barack Obama and Elon Musk.

WHAT TO DO IF YOU GET PHISHED

01



Do NOT reply or click anything else

Stop all interaction with the email immediately. Do not reply, download, or click any more links.

02



Change your passwords immediately

If you entered any credentials, change them right away on the real website, not from the phishing email.

03



Report it to IT or your institution

Notify your university IT team or email provider so they can investigate and warn others.

04



Contact your bank if money is involved

If you entered payment details, call your bank immediately to freeze your card and dispute charges.

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

Enable Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)



Even if someone steals your password, 2FA stops them from logging in.

Always verify the sender's email address



Look closely at the full email address, not just the display name.

Hover before you click any link



Hovering shows the real URL destination before you visit it.

Keep software and apps updated



Updates patch security holes that phishers try to exploit.

Take security awareness training



Like this one! Educated users are the best defence against phishing.

Use a spam filter and antivirus



Good spam filters block many phishing emails before they reach you.

QUICK QUIZ — THINK BEFORE YOU CLICK!

 Inbox — New Message

From: security-alert@paypa1-verify.com

Subject: URGENT: Your account has been suspended!

Dear Customer,

We have detected suspicious activity on your PayPal account. Your account has been temporarily suspended.

Please verify your identity immediately by clicking the link below or your account will be permanently closed within 24 hours.

[Verify My Account Now](#)



RED FLAGS

- ✗ paypa1 (number 1, not letter I)
- ✗ Generic 'Dear Customer'
- ✗ Urgent threat — 24 hour deadline
- ✗ Suspicious sender domain
- ✗ Pressures you to click immediately

KEY TAKEAWAYS



Phishing is deception — attackers pretend to be someone you trust.



Always check the sender's email address carefully before responding.



Hover over links before clicking — the real URL tells the truth.



Enable 2FA on all your accounts — it is your strongest safety net.



If you suspect phishing — stop, report it, and change your passwords.

Remember: YOU are the most important line of defence against phishing.

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